Psychology of Affect and Relationships

The Biology of Emotions: What drives motivation?

Why it is important for us to care and how our professional relationships can make a difference

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Outline

- What is Affect?
- How does it motivate everything we do?
- The importance of relationships?
- The Compass of Shame?
- Learning Shame and Mindset?
- How can we Help?

What is Affect?

- A biological programme hard wired into our central nervous system from birth. It is a brief biological response to stimulus conditions - with an evolved function of directing our attention to what is important for us to care about/focus our attention on.

The Affect System in the Brain Consists of Nine Affects (Tomkins (1962)

Positive Affects

- Interests - Excitement
- Enjoyment-Joy

Neutral Affects

- Surprise - Startle

Negative Affects

- Distress - Anguish
- Fear – Terror
- Anger – Rage
- Shame – Humiliation
- Disgust
- Dismell

Motivation and the Cognitive System

- Affect motivates everything we think or do. We are all wired from birth to experience positive and negative affect based on stimulus conditions around us. We care - are motivated to automatically seek more positive feelings and to stop negative feelings.
- The affect system works in conjunction with many other brain systems - Cognitive systems)
- Memory - ability to analyse and compare experiences
- Scene – Stimulus – Affect - Response

- Scripts
- Feelings
- Emotions

The Central Blueprint

1. Maximise positive affect
2. Minimise negative affect
3. Minimise the inhibition of affect
4. Maximise the power to maximise positive affect , minimise negative affect, and minimise the inhibition of affect.

The Importance of Relationships

- What is the evolved function of affects?

- Focus on the ‘Affect’ – ‘Shame’

How Do We Resolve Uncomfortable Feelings

The Compass of Shame

Adapted from D.L. Nathanson, Shame and Pride, 1992

Withdrawal:
- isolating oneself
- running and hiding

Attack Other:
- 'turning the tables'
- blaming the victim
- lashing out verbally or physically

Attack Self:
- self put-down
- masochism

Avoidance:
- denial
- abusing drugs and alcohol
- distraction through thrill seeking

What Does it All Mean?

- Affects trigger themselves, so that what is triggered in me triggers the same in someone that I am dealing with – which is why emotion is contagious.

- Knowing this and thinking of children who we work with who we feel have impediment to their excitement and joy

- How can we help them maximise positive affect and minimise negative affects through our relationship with them directly and/or with their wider social systems?

Learning Shame

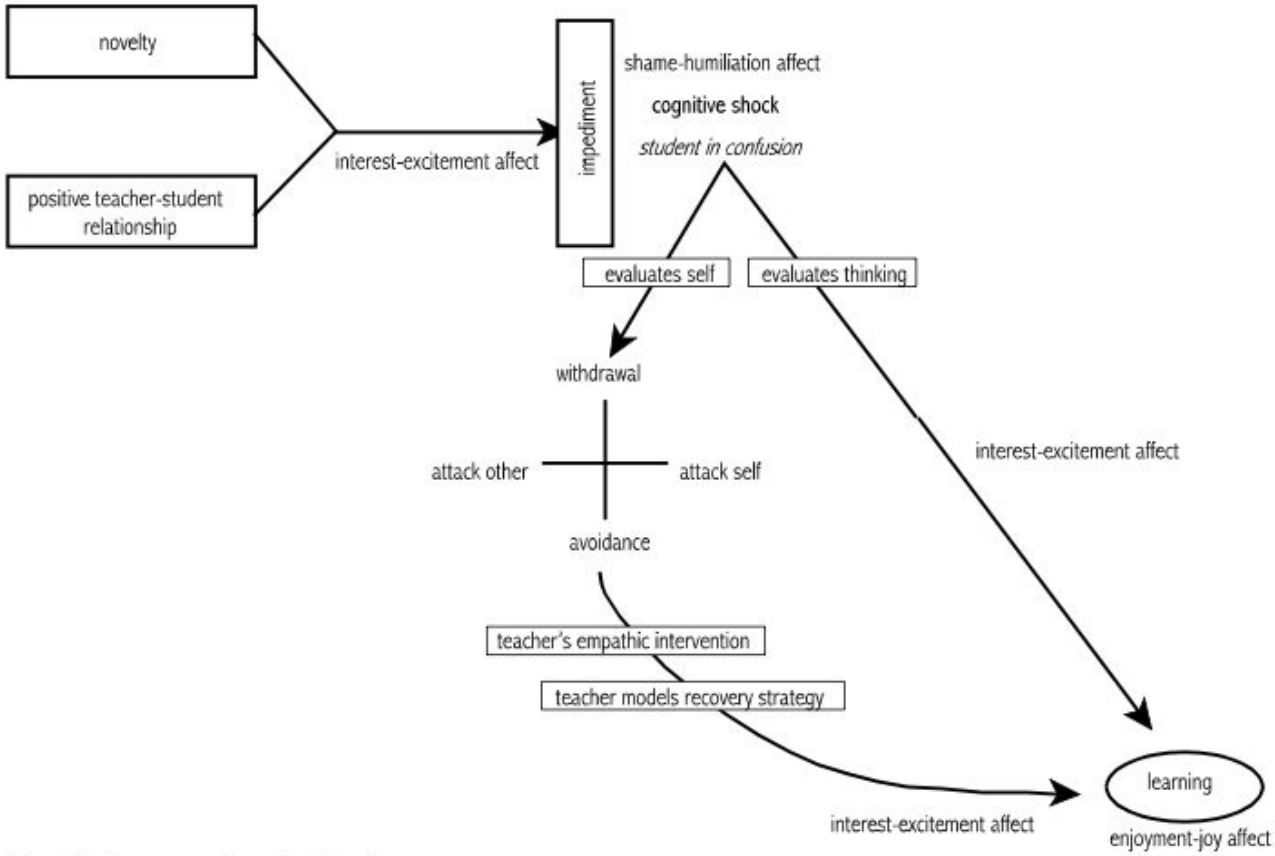
- **Withdraw** - Switch off from learning and not attend lessons.
- **Attack self** - Put themselves down, assume they are dumb.
- **Avoid** - Be the class clown, focus on other aspect of their lives, take risks, use drugs etc.
- **Attack other** - Put others down, belittle value of work, diminish someone, bully others.

Cognitions, Affects, & Behaviours Associated with Mindset

- Pupils have certain self-theories about their ability and have a set of scripts around learning.

- Mindset – Shame Affect is central to complex learning.

The process of complex learning (George, 2014, p.224)



Fixed Mindset

- Pupils believe that their capabilities are fixed since they are part of the self and the self is fixed and constant.

- **Stimulus =** Challenge = self-doubt, helplessness
- **Affect** = distress, fear, anger, shame
- **Behaviour** = risk avoidance, defensiveness, competitiveness, withdrawal hostility, lying.

Growth Mindset

- Pupils believe that capabilities can be developed through effort, i.e., through behaviour.

- **Stimulus** = Challenge = self-confidence, aspiration
- **Affect** = interest-excitement, enjoyment joy
- **Behaviour** = high effort, challenge-seeking, cooperativeness, persistence

Questions to consider about the Mindset of the pupils you support?

- What is their desire/ motivation for learning?
- How do they evaluate situations?
- How do they deal with setbacks?
- How do they deal with setbacks?
- How do they perceive danger?
- How do they perceive effort?
- How do they respond to criticism?
- How do they perceive others success?

How Can We Help?

- Empathic intervention – cant happen without trust and mutual respect (unconditional positive regard)
- Promote a growth mindset

- Establish high expectations (not just high standards).
- Create a risk-tolerant learning zone
- Give feedback that focuses on process – things that he can control
- Focus on how tasks/activities are framed and how feedback is provided

- **Framing tasks**

- Example of communicating learning goals: we are in the learning zone today; mistakes are our friends!

- **Communicating high expectations**

- Example of communicating high expectations: As you learn this, mistakes are expected. Your mistakes help me to support you. Let's make mistakes together!

- **Giving feedback:**

- example of when he struggles despite strong effort: I admire your persistence and I appreciate your hard work. It will pay off!
- Example of when he struggles and needs help with strategies: Let's do one together…
- Example of when he is making progress: I see you using your strategies/tools/notes etc. keep it up!
- Example of when he succeeds with strong effort: I am very proud of you for not giving up and look what you have to show for it!

It is all about relationship quality and our willingness to engage.

Thank You

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